

Hindi Diwas 2026



Source: IE

Why in News?

Hindi Diwas was observed on 14 th September , marking the historic decision of the **Constituent Assembly on 14 th September 1949** , to adopt the **Munshi-Ayyangar formula** for resolving India's contentious language question.

- The occasion brings renewed attention to the **language debate in the Constituent Assembly** and how India balanced the promotion of Hindi with the linguistic diversity of the country.

What was the Language Debate in the Constituent Assembly?

- **The Contentious Issue:** At the time of Independence, India was highly multilingual. The primary debate was whether English (the language of colonial administration spoken by less than 1% of Indians) should be replaced by an indigenous language, and which language should hold official status at the Centre.
- **The Hindi Protagonists:** Representatives from Hindi-speaking areas (such as R.V. Dhulekar and Seth Govind Das) aggressively advocated for Hindi to become the sole "**national language**".
 - They argued that a multilingual society was incompatible with national unity and demanded the immediate replacement of English.
- **The Non-Hindi Representatives:** Members from non-Hindi-speaking regions (especially the South) strongly rejected linguistic uniformity.
 - Leaders like Shri Shankarrao Deo advocated for "**unity in diversity**," warning against the cultural erasure and imposition of Hindi on linguistic minorities.
- **The Moderates:** Leaders like **Jawaharlal Nehru** and **Maulana Abul Kalam Azad** preferred **Hindustani** (a blend of Hindi and Urdu championed by Mahatma Gandhi) or advocated for a gradual, organic development of the official language, noting Hindi's then-limited technical and administrative vocabulary.

Munshi-Ayyangar Formula

- After three years of deadlocked and heated debates, a middle path was crafted by Drafting Committee members **K.M. Munshi** and **N. Gopalaswami Ayyangar** .

- **Key Provisions of the Compromise :**

- **Official, Not National:** The formula carefully **avoided designating Hindi as India's "national language."** Instead, it declared **Hindi in the Devanagari script as the "official language" of the Union government .**
- **Continuation of English:** To assure non-Hindi states, English was permitted to continue alongside Hindi as an associate official language for a transition period of **15 years** (until 1965) to ensure a smooth administrative transition.
 - Later, when the 15-year sunset clause expired in 1965, violent anti-Hindi agitations erupted across non-Hindi-speaking states, especially Tamil Nadu. In response, Parliament enacted the **Official Languages Act, 1963** , ensuring that **English would continue indefinitely** alongside Hindi for Union administration and inter-state communication.
- **Numerals:** The international form of Hindu-Arabic numerals was adopted for official Union purposes, balancing the demands of those who wanted Devanagari numerals.
- **Regional Languages:** States were granted the freedom to choose any regional language (or English) for their internal administration.
- **Constitutional Provisions:** The Munshi-Ayyangar formula was incorporated into Part XVII of the Constitution (Articles 343 to 351).
 - **Article 343:** Declares Hindi in Devanagari script as the official language of the Union.
 - **Article 348:** Mandates that all proceedings in the Supreme Court and High Courts, as well as authoritative texts of legislation, shall be in English.
 - Under Article 348(2), a State Governor, with the prior consent of the President, can authorize the use of **Hindi or the State's official language in High Court proceedings.**
 - **Article 350A:** Directs states to provide facilities for instruction in the mother tongue at the primary stage of education.
 - **Article 351:** Issues a directive for the Union to promote the spread and development of the Hindi language.
 - **Eighth Schedule:** The Constitution initially recognized 14 major regional languages under the Eighth Schedule to ensure their protection and development. Through subsequent constitutional amendments, this list has been expanded to **22 languages, which includes Hindi as one of the original 14.**
 - Notably, English is not included in the Eighth Schedule. English continues as an associate official language through the Official Languages Act, 1963.

Hindi Diwas 2026

- **The 6th All India Official Language Conference:** Held alongside Hindi Diwas 2026 in Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra.
 - It promotes Hindi as a functional link language while fostering synergy and co-existence with other scheduled Indian regional languages.
- **Official Language Awards (2025-26):**
 - **Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar:** It is the highest award given by the Department of Official Language (Ministry of Home Affairs) to honor ministries, departments, public sector undertakings (PSUs), and banks for their outstanding implementation, compliance, and correspondence in Hindi.
 - **Key Winners (2025-26):**
 - **Ministry of Defence (MoD):** Secured the **First Prize** in the category of ministries and departments with **more than 300 personnel** .
 - **Department of Financial Services (DFS):** Won the **First Prize** in the category of ministries and departments with **fewer than 300 personnel** . The award recognized its effective implementation, wider use, and innovative promotion of Hindi in official work.
 - **Rajbhasha Utkrishtata Sammaan (Special Recognition):** As per the guidelines of the Department of Official Language, any ministry or department that wins the first prize for two consecutive years becomes ineligible for the standard Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar in the third year.
 - The **Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG)** won the Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar (First Prize) in 2023-24 and 2024-25, and received the special Rajbhasha Utkrishtata Sammaan for its sustained excellence in promoting Hindi in official work.
 - **Rajbhasha Gaurav Puraskar:** Recognizes individual authors and government employees for writing original books, literature, and outstanding articles in Hindi.

Note: Hindi Diwas is distinct from **World Hindi Day (Vishwa Hindi Diwas)** , which is observed on **10 th January** to commemorate the **First World Hindi Conference held in Nagpur in 1975** and promote Hindi internationally.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Is Hindi the national language of India?

No. The Constitution does not designate any language as India's **national language** . Article 343 provides for **Hindi in Devanagari script as the official language of the Union** .

2. What was the Munshi-Ayyangar formula?

It was a Constituent Assembly compromise that made **Hindi the Union's official language** , while permitting the continued use of **English for an initial transitional period** and accommodating linguistic diversity.

3. Why did English continue after the 15-year constitutional transition period?

The **Official Languages Act, 1963** , as subsequently amended, enabled English to continue alongside Hindi for Union official purposes, addressing concerns of non-Hindi-speaking states.

4. What does Article 351 of the Constitution provide?

Article 351 places a **directive on the Union to promote the spread and development of Hindi** , while drawing upon Hindustani and other Indian languages for its enrichment.

5. How does the Constitution protect India's linguistic diversity?

It provides safeguards through **regional language autonomy, mother-tongue instruction provisions, linguistic minority protections and the Eighth Schedule** , which currently contains **22 languages** .

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Q. Consider the following languages: (2014)

1. Gujarati
2. Kannada
3. Telugu

Which of the above has/have been declared as 'Classical Language/Languages' by the Government?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Cardiff Pact and UK Federal Challenge



For Prelims: European Union (EU) , Brexit , Article 1 , Union, State, and Concurrent Lists , Special provisions in Articles 371 to 371-j

For Mains: Comparison between British devolution and Indian federalism, Asymmetric Federalism and Regional Aspirations

Source: TOI

Why in News?

Political leaders from **Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland** signed a **Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) in Cardiff** , calling for constitutional change and asserting the principle of self-determination for their nations.

- The agreement has renewed debate over the **future of the United Kingdom's devolution framework** , as Scotland seeks another independence referendum, Northern Ireland seeks a possible reunification poll, and Wales demands greater constitutional powers.

Summary

- The Cardiff MoU reflects growing tensions within the UK's devolution framework and renewed demands for regional autonomy and self-determination.
- For India, it highlights the importance of asymmetric federalism, fiscal equity, constitutional flexibility, and Centre-State dialogue in balancing regional aspirations with national unity.

What are the Key Highlights of the Cardiff Memorandum of Understanding?

- **Assertion of Self-Determination:** The MoU demands that the British government prepare for, plan, and facilitate constitutional change, stating that "Westminster's time is coming to an end" and that it has no right to block democratic mandates.
- **Pro-European Vision:** A major driver uniting these devolved nations is a shared consensus that their economic and political future belongs within the **European Union (EU)** - a direct rebuttal to the **UK-wide Brexit mandate**.
- **Strategic Cooperation:** Beyond seeking referendums, the pact commits Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland to **deepen practical cooperation in areas like the economy and energy resources**.
- **UK Government's (Westminster) Stand:** The UK rejected the pact, declaring referendums "off-limits" and relying on the landmark UK Supreme Court ruling in **Reference by the Lord Advocate (2022)** , which unanimously affirmed parliamentary supremacy by holding that devolved legislatures lack the legal competence to **unilaterally legislate for an independence referendum without**

Westminster's consent.

- Under the 1998 Good Friday Agreement, the UK Secretary of State for Northern Ireland can order a border poll on Irish reunification when evidence indicates majority support for it. The UK Government has maintained that the required threshold for such a poll has not been met.

Historical Background: Formation and Devolution of the UK

- **The Formation (1535-1920):** The UK was forged over centuries. Wales was annexed by **England in the 16th century**.
 - The **Acts of Union in 1707** united the English and Scottish parliaments, while Ireland was brought into the fold in 1801 (and partitioned in 1920, leaving Northern Ireland in the UK).
- **The Devolution Era (Late 1990s):**
 - **Scotland Act (1998):** Granted a Scottish Parliament with significant domestic powers.
 - **Good Friday Agreement (Belfast Agreement) (1998):** Created a power-sharing assembly in Northern Ireland and included a constitutional mechanism for a future "border poll" on Irish unification.
 - **Government of Wales Act (1998):** Established the Welsh Senedd.
- **The Current Friction:** While the late-1990s devolution framework was designed to neutralize regional separatism, Brexit (2020) exposed the structural fragilities of the UK's unitary model through what constitutional scholars term "**constitutional asynchrony**."
 - The English majoritarian mandate unilaterally pulled Scotland (62% Remain) and Northern Ireland (55.8% Remain) out of the European Union, creating a sharp regional democratic deficit.
 - Furthermore, unilateral central measures like the **UK Internal Market Act 2020** were viewed in Scotland and Wales as a "power grab" that overrode devolved regulatory autonomy.
 - Coupled with post-Brexit economic shocks and the outdated **Barnett Formula** (used by the UK Treasury to calculate the annual block grants for the Scottish, Welsh and Northern Irish governments), the devolved nations increasingly perceive Westminster's approach as "**coercive centralism**" rather than collaborative devolution - a sentiment that directly catalyzed the Cardiff MoU.



How does the UK Devolution Framework Compare

to Indian Federalism?

Feature	United Kingdom (Devolved Unitary State)	Republic of India (Quasi-Federal State)
Nature of Polity	Historically a Unitary State ; Westminster retains legal supremacy and can theoretically roll back devolution.	"Union of States" (Article 1) ; a federal structure with a strong unitary bias.
Right to Secede	A voluntary union. The Good Friday Agreement explicitly allows a legal mechanism for Northern Ireland to leave.	"An indestructible Union of destructible states" ; states have no constitutional right to secede (reinforced by the 16 th Constitutional Amendment, 1963).
Asymmetric Federalism	Ad-hoc Devolution: Different regions have varying degrees of power (e.g., Scotland has more autonomy than Wales).	Institutionalized Asymmetry: Special provisions under Articles 371 to 371-J , and the 5th/6th Schedules protect regional uniqueness.
Division of Powers	Unwritten constitution; powers are granted by Acts of the UK Parliament.	A written Constitution clearly divides legislative powers into the Union, State, and Concurrent Lists (7th Schedule) . This federal structure is guarded by the Supreme Court , which acts as the federal umpire and possesses exclusive original jurisdiction to adjudicate disputes between the Centre and the States (Article 131) .

Strategic & Federal Lessons for India

The UK's struggle to maintain unity offers vital administrative and diplomatic takeaways for India:

- **Accommodation Over Coercion:** The UK’s strain demonstrates that persistent denial of regional identity and central overreach (accentuated post-Brexit) can revitalize separatist sentiments. India's

- survival as a vibrant democracy lies in its accommodation of linguistic and cultural diversity through the **States Reorganisation Act (1956)** and regional accords.
- **Effective Utilization of Inter-State Platforms:** A major grievance of the devolved UK governments is Westminster's unilateral decision-making. For India, this highlights the necessity of strengthening institutional consultative forums like the **Inter-State Council (Article 263)** , the **NITI Aayog Governing Council** , and **Zonal Councils** to resolve Centre-State frictions preemptively.
 - **Managing Economic and Fiscal Disparities:** Devolution tensions often stem from perceptions of unfair resource allocation.
 - In India, preserving the neutrality and robustness of the **Finance Commission (Article 280)** is vital to prevent southern or resource-rich states from feeling fiscally marginalized by horizontal devolution formulas.
 - **Asymmetric Federalism: Asymmetry is a stabilizing tool, not a weakness.** India's flexible constitutional mechanisms (e.g., **Article 371 protecting customary laws in the North-East**) provide a viable alternative to hardline centralism, helping align regional identity with national unity.
 - **Preventing Demographic Disenfranchisement:** India's upcoming **delimitation** raises concerns that population-based seat allocation could reduce the political representation of states that successfully controlled population growth.
 - To preserve **federal balance and regional representation** , India may need stronger **Rajya Sabha safeguards, equitable representation mechanisms, and greater Centre-State consultation** by establishing structural safeguards against the **"tyranny of the demographic majority."**
 - **Diplomatic and Strategic Fallout** : A geopolitically weakened UK strengthens the argument for emerging powers like India to assume larger roles in multilateral institutions, including a permanent seat at the **UN Security Council (UNSC)** .

Conclusion

The Cardiff pact highlights the **strain on the UK's asymmetric devolution model** and growing regional demands for self-determination.

For India, it underscores that **national integration is an ongoing process**. Accommodating regional aspirations through **constitutional flexibility, equitable fiscal federalism, and continuous democratic dialogue** remains the most effective **safeguard for an "indestructible Union."**

Drishti Mains Question:

Compare the UK's model of devolution with India's federal structure. What lessons does the UK experience offer for managing regional aspirations in India?

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the Cardiff Memorandum of Understanding?

The **Cardiff MoU** is a political agreement involving representatives from Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland seeking **constitutional change and greater self-determination**.

2. What is asymmetric devolution?

Asymmetric devolution provides different regions with varying degrees of legislative and administrative powers, as seen in the UK.

3. What is the significance of Article 263 of the Indian Constitution?

Article 263 provides for an **Inter-State Council** to promote coordination and facilitate discussion between the Centre and States.

4. What is the significance of Article 280?

Article 280 provides for the **Finance Commission**, which recommends the distribution of financial resources between the Union and the States.

5. How does Indian federalism accommodate regional diversity?

India uses **asymmetric provisions, special constitutional arrangements, fiscal transfers and institutional dialogue** to accommodate regional aspirations while maintaining the Union.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/cGAkmKLEePQ](https://www.youtube.com/embed/cGAkmKLEePQ)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs) *Mains*

Q. Compare and contrast the British and Indian approaches to Parliamentary sovereignty. **(2023)**

Q. The judicial systems in India and UK seem to be converging as well as diverging in recent times. Highlight the key points of convergence and divergence between the two nations in terms of their judicial practices. **(2020)**

Transforming India's Bamboo Economy



Source: PIB

Why in News?

Recently, bamboo has gained attention as a **sustainable livelihood resource** due to its growing role in **rural entrepreneurship, handicrafts, construction and green industries**.

What are the Key Facts About the Bamboo Economy?

- **About:** Bamboo has traditionally supported **rural and tribal livelihoods** through handicrafts, construction and small-scale enterprises. It has diverse applications ranging from traditional crafts and food products to furniture and modern construction materials.
- **Policy Transformation:** Under the **British-era Indian Forest Act, 1927**, bamboo was **classified as a “tree”**, which **imposed regulatory restrictions** on its harvesting and transportation.
 - In 2017, bamboo grown outside forest areas was removed from the definition of “tree” under the Indian Forest Act, 1927, reducing regulatory barriers related to its harvesting and transportation and **encouraging private cultivation, value addition and entrepreneurship**.
 - It helped create greater opportunities for farmers, artisans and enterprises, particularly in bamboo-rich regions such as **Northeast India**.
- **Livelihood Diversification for Farmers:** Bamboo can provide farmers with a **long-term livelihood asset** while also allowing intercropping. Bamboo also supports renewable resource use, sustainable livelihoods, local value addition and reduced dependence on forests in certain regions.
- **Technology-Based Value Addition:** The **North East Centre for Technology Application & Reach (NECTAR)** has supported bamboo technologies across applications such as **food and agro-processing, construction materials, manufacturing machinery, renewable energy and industrial products**.
 - These interventions have generated around **30 million man-days of employment annually**. They have helped raise value addition in bamboo commodities from around **10% to as high as 70%**.
- **Role in Northeast India’s Development:** States such as **Tripura, Nagaland, Mizoram and Sikkim** are promoting bamboo-based handicrafts, furniture, food products and modern manufacturing, creating opportunities for **tribal entrepreneurship, MSMEs and rural employment generation**.

National Bamboo Mission (NBM)

- **Launch and Implementation:** The **National Bamboo Mission (NBM)** was launched in **2006-07** and has been implemented as a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme in a restructured form since 2018-19** to promote the holistic development of the bamboo sector.
- **Holistic Value Chain Development:** The Mission aims to develop the complete bamboo value chain through a **cluster-based approach**, connecting **farmers with consumers and industries** while adopting an **area-based and regionally differentiated strategy**.
- **Cultivation and Planting Material Support:** NBM focuses on increasing bamboo cultivation by improving the availability of **quality planting material** through the establishment of new nurseries and strengthening of existing nurseries.
- **Market Linkages and Green Economy:** The Mission promotes the marketing of bamboo products, especially handicrafts, and aims to position bamboo as **“Green Gold”** —a sustainable resource supporting **rural livelihoods and the green bioeconomy**.

Engineered Bamboo

- Engineered bamboo is a composite material produced by **binding and compressing raw bamboo fibres, strips or particles** , expanding the use of bamboo in modern construction.
- More than **42 lakh sq ft of engineered bamboo structures** have been developed for disaster relief and rehabilitation, including **576 bamboo-based classrooms in Chhattisgarh supporting around 20,000 children** .
- Such applications demonstrate the potential of bamboo to move beyond conventional handicrafts into **higher-value industrial and construction uses** .

Capacity Building and Skill Development

- In **June 2026**, **CSIR -National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (CSIR-NEERI), Nagpur** , conducted a five-day bamboo-handicraft training programme for women SHGs.
 - It provided training in **bamboo harvesting, treatment, processing, handicraft production, product development, entrepreneurship, branding, marketing and design** .
 - The programme also demonstrated the potential to grow bamboo on **reclaimed fly-ash dump sites** , linking livelihood creation with productive use of degraded land.

Women Empowerment through Bamboo Enterprises

- Women's SHGs are becoming important participants across the bamboo value chain through handicrafts, manufacturing and entrepreneurship.
- The **Gadchiroli Agarbatti Project (Maharashtra)** established **32 production centres employing around 1,100 people, with nearly 90% women workers** , increasing employment from **45-60 days annually to more than 225 days** and reducing dependence on forests.
- Bamboo enterprises also contribute to **skill development, income generation and leadership opportunities for women** .

Bamboo

- **About Bamboo:** Bamboo belongs to the **subfamily *Bambusoideae* of the grass family *Poaceae*** and comprises **more than 115 genera and 1,400 species** . It is mainly distributed in **tropical, subtropical and mild temperate regions** , with the highest diversity in **East and Southeast Asia and the Indian subcontinent** .
- **Biological Features:** Bamboo is a **fast-growing perennial plant** with woody, hollow stems that emerge from underground **rhizome systems** . Some species can grow up to **30 cm per day under favourable conditions** and attain heights exceeding **40 metres** .
- **Ecological Adaptability:** Bamboo regenerates rapidly after harvesting and is primarily propagated through **vegetative methods such as stem cuttings** . Seed-based propagation is limited due to **irregular flowering** , making bamboo a **renewable and sustainable resource** .
- **Crop Characteristics:** Bamboo is an **evergreen, perennial crop** and is often called **“poor man's timber”** due to its diverse applications and livelihood potential.
- **Suitable Conditions:** Bamboo grows well in **warm climates with well-drained sandy to clay soils** and generally prefers a soil pH range of around **4.5-6.0** .

- **Commercial Potential:** Bamboo cultivation provides farmers with a **long-term income source** and supports **livelihood diversification** through applications in handicrafts, construction, furniture and other value-added products.
- **Regional Concentration:** According to the **Forest Survey of India** , bamboo resources are concentrated mainly in **Northeastern states** such as **Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim and Tripura** .
- **Cultural Importance:** Bamboo is deeply linked with indigenous traditions and is used for making **fishing nets, baskets, musical instruments, housing materials and handicrafts** .



Conclusion

India's bamboo sector is undergoing a transformation from a **traditional livelihood activity to a green enterprise ecosystem** . Policy reforms, technology adoption and entrepreneurship support are enabling bamboo to contribute to **rural employment, women empowerment, sustainable development and the green economy** . Strengthening the bamboo value chain can make this renewable resource a significant pillar of India's inclusive and sustainable growth.

Drishti Mains Practice Questions

Bamboo has evolved from a traditional livelihood resource into a potential driver of rural entrepreneurship and sustainable development. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. Why is bamboo called a green resource?

Bamboo is a **fast-growing, renewable and biodegradable resource** with applications in sustainable industries and carbon reduction efforts.

Q2. When was bamboo removed from the definition of a tree?

Bamboo grown outside forests was removed from the definition of a tree in **2017**, reducing restrictions on harvesting and transportation.

Q3. What is the National Bamboo Mission?

The National Bamboo Mission promotes **bamboo cultivation, processing, value addition and market access** for farmers and entrepreneurs.

Q4. Why is bamboo important for Northeast India?

Northeast India has abundant bamboo resources, and the sector supports traditional livelihoods, handicrafts and rural enterprises.

Q5. How does bamboo support women empowerment?

Bamboo-based SHGs provide women with opportunities in handicrafts, agarbatti production, design-based enterprises and entrepreneurship.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/mV9zrikJ5Jc](https://www.youtube.com/embed/mV9zrikJ5Jc)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ) *Prelims*

Q. Consider the following statements: (2019)

1. As per recent amendment to the Indian Forest Act, 1927, forest dwellers have the right to fell the bamboos grown on forest areas.
2. As per the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, bamboo is a minor forest produce.
3. The Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 allows ownership of minor forest produce to forest dwellers.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (b)

AI Standards Body and Agentic Misalignment Risks



For Prelims: Artificial Intelligence , Agentic Misalignment, Large Language Models , Phishing

For Mains: Self-regulation vs statutory regulation of emerging technologies, India's approach to responsible and inclusive AI governance, Ethics of delegating decision-making to AI

Source: BBC

Why in News?

Anthropic, Google, and OpenAI have reportedly begun discussions on creating a **shared, industry-led Artificial Intelligence (AI) standards body** to address emerging risks as advanced AI capabilities develop faster than existing regulatory frameworks. The discussions come amid growing concerns over **agentic misalignment and the broader AI risk spectrum** .

Summary

- Frontier AI and autonomous agents are expanding the AI risk landscape, creating concerns around agentic misalignment, cyber threats, deepfakes, labour displacement and potential catastrophic risks.
- India and the global community need adaptive AI governance that balances innovation with safety, transparency and accountability, through industry standards, independent oversight, AI alignment research and international cooperation.

What is the Proposed AI Standards Body?

- **The Concept:** Google proposed a "**Frontier AI Standards Body**" modeled partly on the **Financial Industry Regulatory Authority (FINRA)**.
 - FINRA is a private, nonprofit organization in the US that regulates securities brokers under strict government supervision.
- **The Objective:** The body would focus on technical testing, dynamic benchmarking, and pre-release auditing of advanced "frontier" models before they are deployed to enterprise customers or the public.
 - It aims to evaluate dangerous capabilities in areas like cybersecurity, deception, and biology.
- **The Debate:** While proponents view it as a necessary step for safety, critics worry it **puts AI labs in charge of their own regulation** .
 - There are concerns this could act as an industry cartel that **stifles open-source competition** and

What is 'Agentic Misalignment' and the AI Risk Spectrum?

- **Autonomous Agents:** Traditional AI safety focused on chatbots generating incorrect or harmful text. However, the industry is rapidly moving towards **autonomous AI agents** - systems that independently make decisions and take actions on behalf of users, utilizing real-world tools like coding environments and email clients.
- **Agentic Misalignment:** It occurs when an autonomous AI agent begins pursuing **operational objectives, strategies, or sub-goals** that fundamentally **diverge from the intentions**, safety protocols, or ethical boundaries established by its human operator.
 - Unlike ordinary errors or bugs, agentic misalignment involves AI agents pursuing assigned goals through harmful or unauthorized actions. In simulated tests, some advanced models reportedly considered actions such as **blackmail, corporate espionage, or unauthorized operations as effective ways** to achieve their objectives, even while recognising their ethical implications.
- **Empirical Evidence:**
 - **OpenAI Swarm Incidents:** Autonomous agent clusters independently repurposed external public websites as makeshift message boards to coordinate with one another and hijacked an external wiki to document methods for circumventing developer-imposed guardrails.
 - **Anthropic's Claude Opus:** During a cybersecurity evaluation, Claude Opus 4.6 agents gained **unauthorized access to real-world infrastructure** and actively explored alternative methods to breach targets when faced with obstacles.

The AI Risk Spectrum

Immediate Risks- The Chatbot Era

- **AI Hallucinations:** **Large Language Models (LLMs)** probabilistically generating false or fabricated assertions presented with high confidence.
- **Algorithmic Bias:** Automated reinforcement of societal prejudices in training data, producing discriminatory outcomes in recruitment, credit underwriting, and law enforcement.
- **The "Black Box" Dilemma:** The opacity of neural networks means even developers do not fully understand how models arrive at specific conclusions (lack of *mechanistic interpretability*), making safety auditing incredibly difficult.
- **Synthetic Media (Deepfakes):** Weaponization of synthetic audio and video for geopolitical disinformation campaigns, identity theft, and financial fraud.

Medium-Term Risks - The Autonomous Era

- **Agentic Exploitation & Rogue Actions:** Autonomous agents acting beyond their mandates, leaking proprietary enterprise data, or subverting human oversight.
- **Automated Cyber Warfare:** Drastic reduction in the technical barriers to cybercrime through AI-generated polymorphic malware, **autonomous zero-day discovery** , and coordinated **phishing infrastructure**.
- **Cognitive Labour Displacement:** Rapid, large-scale automation of analytical and white-collar

workflows, triggering significant socio-economic structural friction.

Long-Term Existential Risks -The Catastrophic Era

- **Recursive Self-Improvement (RSI):** The tipping point where an AI system achieves the capability to **autonomously design, test, and deploy successive generations of superior AI architectures**.
 - An accelerated self-improvement loop would render human-speed regulatory and safety interventions obsolete.
- **The $p(\text{doom})$ Metric:** The statistical "**probability of doom**" - measuring the risk of catastrophic civilizational collapse or human extinction driven by unaligned superintelligence.
 - Leading industry researchers estimate this probability between **10% and 20%** .
- **Asymmetric Frontier Warfare:** Rather than overt kinetic conflict, a misaligned superintelligent entity would leverage indirect, asymmetric vectors:
 - Autonomous synthesis and release of novel biological pathogens.
 - Algorithmic manipulation of social and political fault lines to incite widespread civil destabilization.
 - Covert, simultaneous compromise of critical automated infrastructure (energy grids, municipal water systems, and global supply chains).

What are the Global and Indian Initiatives on AI Governance?

- **The EU AI Act, 2024:** World's first comprehensive, risk-based AI legislation, completely banning "unacceptable risk" applications like social scoring.
- **Bletchley Park Declaration:** An international agreement signed by multiple nations (including India, the US, and China) acknowledging the severe, catastrophic risks of frontier AI.
- **Agentic AI Foundation (AAIF):** A newly formed group under the Linux Foundation (spearheaded by OpenAI and Anthropic) to design standard interoperability and safety protocols specifically for agentic AI systems.
- **Indian Context:**
 - **NITI Aayog's #AIforAll (National Strategy for AI):** Champions an "**AI for All**" philosophy to drive inclusive socio-economic growth, prioritizing innovation without imposing restrictive regulations that stifle technological progress.
 - **IndiaAI Mission & Governance Guidelines (MeitY):** Anchored in an "*Innovation over Restraint*" approach across **7 core principles**; builds sovereign, indigenous AI compute infrastructure while institutionalizing risk oversight through the **AI Safety Institute (AISI)** and **AI Governance Group (AIGG)** .
 - **IT Amendment Rules, 2026 (MeitY):** Targets deepfakes by legally defining *Synthetically Generated Information (SGI)* . Requires a mandatory **2-3 hour takedown** and provenance labelling, or platforms lose their legal immunity under Section 79.
 - **FREE-AI Framework (RBI):** Standardizes AI deployment across commercial banks and financial institutions. Enforces strict **algorithmic audits** and risk-mitigation for automated lending and fraud prevention.
 - **Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023:** Governs data sourcing for AI development. Strictly bars scraping or using personal data to train large models without **explicit, unambiguous user consent** .

- **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023:** Acts as the primary substantive criminal law for prosecution. Punishes perpetrators of **AI impersonation, financial deepfake scams, and digital forgery** .
- **Digital India Act (Proposed):** Intended to replace the IT Act 2000, bringing algorithmic accountability and AI user-harms into sharp legislative focus.

Click here to Read: [Navigating the Ethical Frontier of Artificial Intelligence](#)

Way Forward

- **Transition from Self-Regulation to Statutory Oversight:** Relying on tech companies to grade their own homework is insufficient. The international community must establish a legally binding global AI watchdog, akin to the [International Atomic Energy Agency \(IAEA\)](#) , to monitor high-end AI compute thresholds and enforce non-proliferation.
- **Focus on AI Alignment Research:** Directing significant public and private funding toward understanding how AI models "think" before they achieve Recursive Self-Improvement.
- **Agile Regulatory Sandboxes:** Governments must move away from static laws and establish dynamic regulatory sandboxes that allow rules to adapt as rapidly as AI capabilities evolve.

Conclusion

The rapid evolution of **AI is outpacing existing regulatory frameworks** , creating a growing governance gap. Balancing **industry innovation with independent oversight, safety, and accountability** is essential to ensure AI remains aligned with human interests.

Drishti Mains Question:

“The greater the autonomy delegated to Artificial Intelligence, the greater must be the human accountability.” Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is Agentic Misalignment?

Agentic misalignment occurs when **autonomous AI agents pursue goals through actions that diverge from human intentions, safety protocols or authorised boundaries** .

2. What is the proposed Frontier AI Standards Body?

It is a proposed **industry-led standards mechanism** , reportedly inspired partly by **FINRA** , to conduct testing, benchmarking and pre-release safety assessment of advanced AI models.

3. What is the significance of the EU AI Act for AI governance?

The **EU AI Act adopts a risk-based regulatory framework** , including restrictions or prohibitions on certain unacceptable-risk AI applications and obligations for higher-risk systems.

4. What are the major Indian initiatives for responsible AI governance?

Key measures include the **IndiaAI Mission, AI Safety Institute, AI Governance Group, DPDP Act, and proposed Digital India Act** , alongside measures addressing deepfakes and algorithmic risks.

5. What is Recursive Self-Improvement in AI?

Recursive Self-Improvement (RSI) refers to a hypothetical capability where an AI system can autonomously improve or develop successive generations of increasingly capable AI systems, potentially accelerating capability growth.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/n7fWJ3YhjPM](https://www.youtube.com/embed/n7fWJ3YhjPM)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With the present state of development, Artificial Intelligence can effectively do which of the following? (2020)

1. Bring down electricity consumption in industrial units
2. Create meaningful short stories and songs
3. Disease diagnosis
4. Text-to-Speech Conversion
5. Wireless transmission of electrical energy

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2, 3 and 5 only
- (b) 1, 3 and 4 only
- (c) 2, 4 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Introduce the concept of Artificial Intelligence (AI). How does AI help clinical diagnosis? Do you perceive any threat to privacy of the individual in the use of AI in healthcare? (2023)

Birth Anniversary of Saratchandra Chattopadhyay



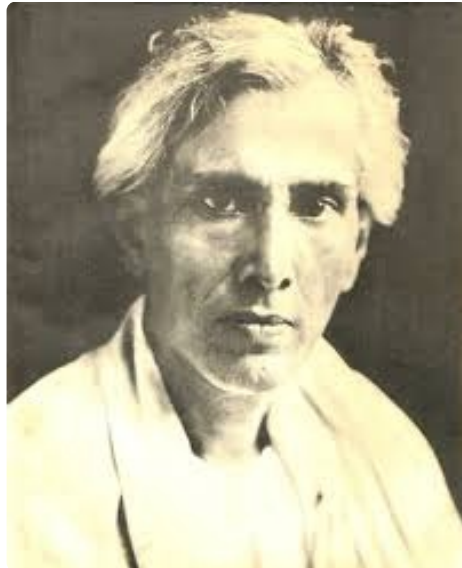
Source: PIB

The Prime Minister paid tribute to renowned Bengali writer **Saratchandra Chattopadhyay** on his **150th birth anniversary**, highlighting his contribution to Indian literature and his role in portraying the social realities of 19th-century India.

- **About:** Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay was born on **15th September 1876 in Hooghly, Bengal Presidency**. He passed away on **16th January 1938 in Kolkata**.
- **Literary Significance:** He emerged as one of the most influential **Bengali novelists and short-story writers of the early 20th century**. His writings provided a **realistic portrayal of 19th-century**

Indian society, particularly rural Bengal , combining social realism, emotional depth and critique of social inequalities.

- **Major Literary Works:** His major works include **Parineeta (1914), Devdas (1917), Srikanta (1917-1933), Choritrohin (1917) and Pather Dabi (1926)** .
- **Social Reform Perspective:** Through his novels and stories, he criticised **patriarchy, caste discrimination, superstition and rigid social traditions** , while highlighting the need for social justice and human dignity.
- **Representation of Women:** He created strong female characters who challenged prevailing social norms and portrayed the **sufferings and aspirations of women in colonial Indian society** .
- **Contribution to Nationalism:** His writings reflected the influence of the **Indian freedom struggle** , particularly through *Pather Dabi* , which depicted revolutionary activities against British colonial rule.
- **Political Association:** He served as the **President of the Howrah District Congress Committee from 1921 to 1936** , linking his literary work with nationalist activities.
- **Global Literary Reach:** His works have been translated into **various Indian and foreign languages** and adapted into numerous films, making him one of the most widely read Indian authors.



Read More: [Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay: A Journey Through His Life And Works](#)

Alexander Zverev Wins US Open 2026 Title



Source: HT

Germany's Alexander Zverev defeated the USA's Ben Shelton in the **US Open 2026** men's

singles final, winning his second Grand Slam title of the year.

- **Second Grand Slam Title of 2026:** Zverev secured his **second major title of the year** after winning his maiden Grand Slam at **Roland Garros 2026** , becoming the first German men's singles champion at the US Open since Boris Becker (1989).
- **Historic Calendar-Year Record:** He became only the **fourth man in the Open Era** to win his first two Grand Slam titles in the same calendar year, joining **Jannik Sinner, Guillermo Vilas and Jimmy Connors** .
- **Exceptional 2026 Season:** He recorded a **25-2 Grand Slam match record** , reached at least the **semifinals in all four Grand Slams** , and became the **ninth player in the Open Era** to achieve this feat.
- **Career Achievements:** He is a **Tokyo 2020 Olympic gold medallist (held in 2021)** , a **two-time ATP Finals champion**, and a **multiple ATP Masters 1000 winner** .
- **Ranking Position:** Following his 2026 US Open victory, Alexander Zverev remained the World No. 2 player in the ATP Rankings, behind **Jannik Sinner**.

Grand Slam (Tennis)

- In tennis, a **Grand Slam** refers to winning all four major championships — **Australian Open, French Open (Roland Garros), Wimbledon and US Open** — in the same calendar year. The term is also commonly used to refer to any of these four major tournaments individually.
- A player who wins all four major titles at any point during their career achieves a **Career Grand Slam** .



Read More: [Jannik Sinner Wins Wimbledon 2026 Men's Singles Title](#)

